

Arthur's Seat - Kids

UK Family Tour

You Are Climbing a Volcano

Today you're climbing an actual volcano. Arthur's Seat erupted about three hundred and fifty million years ago — long before dinosaurs, when Scotland sat near the equator and this whole area was a steamy tropical swamp beside a shallow sea. The volcano is thoroughly extinct — the geologists promise — and ice-age glaciers have since scraped it into the lion-shaped hill you see. Lots of people think it looks like a sleeping lion: the summit is the lion's head, and the long ridge is its body. Nobody knows for sure where the name comes from. The romantic story says it's King Arthur's seat, and some legends even claim Arthur and his knights sleep in a cave under the hill, waiting for Scotland's hour of greatest need. As you walk the path under Salisbury Crags — the big cliff of orange rock — you're in a genuinely famous place for science: a man named James Hutton studied these exact rocks in the 1780s and realized the Earth must be unimaginably older than anyone believed. People used to think Earth was six thousand years old. Hutton looked at these crags and proved it took millions upon millions of years. He basically discovered deep time — right here. Keep an eye out for the ruined chapel on the smaller hill, and for rabbits, which own this park.

The People Who Lived on the Volcano

Long before anyone climbed this hill for fun, people lived up here. Right on the summit you're heading for, more than two thousand years ago, there was a fort. Iron Age families built it as a stronghold, a safe high place they could defend. Look for two low stony banks running along the eastern side of the hill. Those humps are the worn-down remains of the fort's ramparts, the walls that once guarded the gap between the top and the smaller peak beside it. And here's a surprise: this hill isn't the only fort in the park. There were four altogether, on different crags around you, so the whole place was once dotted with hilltop homes.

The people who lived here are called the Votadini, and we barely know them, but we do have one amazing thing: a very old poem, written down around the year six hundred, that remembers their warriors. Imagine that. The people who watched the sunrise from this exact spot are so old that they live on only in a song.

Now look at the lower slopes on the eastern side, the ones facing the little village of Duddingston. When the sun is low and the light goes slanty, you can see long flat steps cut into the grass, like giant stairs. Those are cultivation terraces. Ancient farmers carved flat shelves into the steep hillside so they could plough and grow food without everything rolling downhill. They're some of the best-preserved anywhere near Edinburgh, and most people walk right past without noticing them.

There's one more human ruin to spot, and it's a good one. On a rocky shoulder above a little loch stands the broken shell of St Anthony's Chapel, a stone building from the Middle Ages. Nobody is completely sure why it was built here, or exactly when, which is wonderfully mysterious for a whole chapel. Perhaps monks or a lone holy man once lived beside it, saying prayers with that huge view spread out below, watching ships come up the river. Today only one tall corner still stands, like a stone finger pointing at the sky.

So as you climb, remember you're not the first. Think of the fort-builders hauling stones to the top, the farmers digging their terraces, the hermit in his little chapel. For thousands of years, people have chosen this old volcano as a place to live, to farm, to pray, and to keep watch. You're just the newest visitors in a very, very long line, and the hill has quietly kept all their marks for you to find.

The Best View in the City

When you finally reach the top, stop, catch your breath, and turn slowly all the way around. You're standing two hundred and fifty-one metres up, on the highest point for miles, and on a clear day this is one of the best views in Scotland. Let's play a game of I-spy from the roof of Edinburgh.

Look west first, back the way most people come. There's the whole Old Town spilling down a long ridge, with Edinburgh Castle perched on its own crag at the far end. Here's the secret: that castle rock is a volcano too, a cousin of the one you're standing on, born from the same fiery time. You're looking from one dead volcano across to another.

Now turn to the north. That wide sheet of silvery water is the Firth of Forth, where the river meets the sea. Beyond it is a whole other region called Fife. On a clear day you can spot the Forth bridges away to the west, about twelve miles off. One of them is a giant red railway bridge that's more than a hundred and thirty years old, so long that trains have been rumbling across it since your great-great-grandparents were children.

Swing round to the east now, out toward the open sea, and look for a pale lump of rock sitting in the water. That's the Bass Rock, and believe it or not, it's yet another ancient volcano. It looks white from here, but that colour isn't snow or paint. It's birds. Tens of thousands of seabirds called gannets nest on it every summer, so many that they turn the whole rock white. Near it you might see a pointed hill called North Berwick Law, another volcano again. This whole coast is a graveyard of them.

Look south and you'll find a long green wall of hills on the horizon. Those are the Pentlands. And on a truly perfect, sparkling day, if you're really lucky, you can see far to the north-west all the way to the edge of the Highlands, the wild mountains that fill the top half of Scotland.

Right below your feet is the city itself, laid out like a model railway. See if you can find the palace with its towers, which is where the King stays when he's in Scotland, and the modern parliament building beside it. Trace the streets, spot the church spires, watch the tiny buses.

Not many cities let you climb a wild, rocky mountain and look down on the whole thing at once. Take a photo in your head. This is a view people have been climbing up to enjoy for thousands of years, and now it's yours.

Dragons, Knights, and a Road Built by Hand

Every good hill needs good stories, and this one has piles of them. Start with the name itself, Arthur's Seat. Nobody actually knows where it comes from, which leaves plenty of room for legends, and people have happily filled that room for hundreds of years.

The most famous story says the hill is named for King Arthur, the legendary king with the round table and the sword in the stone. Some versions go further and whisper that Arthur and his knights aren't dead at all, but sleeping in a hidden cave deep inside the hill, in their armour, waiting. The tale says that one day, when Scotland needs them most, a horn will sound and they'll wake and ride out. Now, is any of that true? Almost certainly not. But it's a wonderful thing to think about while you stand on top of their supposed roof.

Here's an even better one. The story goes that this whole hill is a dragon. A great dragon once feasted on

the fields around Edinburgh until it was so enormously stuffed and sleepy that it curled up right here to rest, and it fell into such a deep sleep that grass grew over it, and it slowly turned to stone. So when you climb the long ridge, some people say you're clambering up the back of a sleeping dragon. Look at the shape of the hill and see if you agree. Again, it's a story, not a fact, but it's a brilliant one.

There's a real tradition here too, and this one people genuinely still do. On the first morning of May, before the sun is properly up, folk climb the hill and wash their faces in the cold morning dew, because there's an old belief it makes you beautiful and lucky for the year. So on one dawn each spring, this hilltop fills with laughing, shivering people patting wet grass on their cheeks.

Now look down at the bottom of the big orange cliffs for a path called the Radical Road. Back in 1820, times were hard and many weavers, people whose job was making cloth, had no work and no money. So they were given the task of building this very path along the foot of the crags, and the famous writer Walter Scott is the one who suggested it. They laid every stone by hand. These days parts of it are closed off, because chunks of rock sometimes tumble down from above.

That's a good reminder. This hill is real and a bit wild. The dark rock gets very slippery when it's wet, so if today is rainy, take the gentler path under Salisbury Crags rather than scrambling to the very top. Dragons or no dragons, we want you coming home in one piece.

The Mystery of the Seventeen Tiny Coffins

Here's a real unsolved mystery from this exact hill. One day in 1836, five boys were hunting rabbits on Arthur's Seat when they found a small cave hidden behind slabs of rock. Inside, arranged carefully in rows, were seventeen miniature coffins, each about the size of your hand. And inside each tiny coffin was a little carved wooden figure, with a painted face and hand-stitched clothes, tucked in like it was sleeping. Nobody knew who made them, who hid them, or why. Newspapers went wild. Was it witchcraft? A sailor's charm to protect friends lost at sea? A child's secret game? The creepiest theory points to a crime: just eight years earlier, the killers Burke and Hare had murdered sixteen people in Edinburgh and sold the bodies. Sixteen victims, plus their first body — a man who died naturally — makes seventeen. Was someone giving each victim a secret, tiny funeral, since their real bodies never got one? We will never know for sure. The boys, being boys, reportedly threw a few at each other, but eight coffins survived, and you can see them in the National Museum of Scotland — for free — if the weather turns today. Look around as you walk. If a cave could hide here for years in a busy city park... what else might still be hidden?

The Little Coffins Up Close

Let's get a proper look at these strange little coffins, because the closer you look, the stranger and more wonderful they get. Whoever made them wasn't scribbling something silly in five minutes. They were careful, patient, and really quite skilled.

Each coffin is tiny, only about ninety-five millimetres long, which is roughly the length of your finger. Each one was made from a single little block of wood, hollowed out and shaped, with a lid that lifted off just like a real coffin. And they weren't left plain. The maker decorated the outsides with small pieces of tin, pressed into neat diamond shapes and dotted along the wood, as if these little boxes deserved to look proper and finished, not thrown together.

Now open one in your imagination and meet the figure inside. Each coffin held a small wooden person, carved with a face, with little arms, lying on its back as though peacefully asleep. And here's the clever, spooky detail that detectives spotted much later. The figures weren't carved from scratch to be dead people. They seem to have started life as toy soldiers. Someone took ordinary little wooden soldiers, the kind a child might play with, and quietly changed them. In some cases the arms were trimmed away so the figures would fit neatly inside their boxes. Then each one was dressed in real clothes, tiny outfits stitched and glued around the wooden bodies, and tucked in.

Think about what that means. Somebody sat somewhere, probably by candlelight, turning cheerful toy soldiers into a row of little corpses in a row of little coffins. Not one. Seventeen. That's a lot of quiet, careful, secret work.

The people who studied the coffins even tried to guess what kind of person made them, just from the tool marks left in the wood. The cuts suggest someone used to working with sharp metal tools, maybe a shoemaker or a tinsmith, someone whose hands were good at small, exact jobs. So probably not a bored child, but a grown-up who knew what they were doing.

And remember where they were hidden. Not just dropped on the ground, but tucked into a small cave on the hillside, sealed behind three pointed slabs of slate stood up like a little doorway. Someone wanted them hidden, but they also arranged them neatly inside, in careful rows, almost respectfully, as if this hidden cave were a secret little graveyard.

So we have skill, we have patience, we have seventeen of them, and we have a hiding place chosen on purpose. Every single one of those details is a clue. The trouble is, nobody left a note to say what the clues add up to. That's the puzzle, and coming up, we'll put on our detective hats and weigh the best guesses.

Detective Time: Who and Why?

So who made the seventeen tiny coffins, and why on earth did they hide them on this hill? Time to think like a detective. We have clues but no confession, so everything that follows is a guess. Nobody has ever proved any of it. That's important, so hold onto it: these are theories, not answers.

Here's the first idea: witchcraft. Long ago, some people believed you could work magic on someone by making a little model of them. Cast a spell on the doll, and something bad would happen to the real person. Maybe the coffins were seventeen little curses. But detectives point out a problem. If you were cursing someone, you'd usually stab or burn or smash the little figure. You wouldn't gently dress it in stitched clothes and lay it lovingly in a decorated coffin. These figures were treated with care, almost kindness. So the witchcraft idea has a hole in it.

Second idea: sailors. In those days the sea was dangerous, and sailors drowned far from home all the time, with no body to bury and no grave to visit. There was a custom of making a small token, a stand-in, for a friend lost at sea, so he could be remembered properly. Could the coffins be seventeen lost sailors, each given a tiny burial by someone who loved them? It's possible. But nobody has found a shipwreck or a crew that matches, so it stays a maybe.

Now the idea most experts like best, and it's a chilling one. Cast your mind back to Burke and Hare, the two men who murdered people in Edinburgh and sold the bodies to be cut up for anatomy lessons. Their victims never got proper funerals, because their bodies were destroyed. And here's the part that makes detectives sit up: the numbers fit almost exactly. Burke and Hare were connected to seventeen dead people, sixteen they murdered and one who had died naturally. Seventeen victims with no graves. Seventeen tiny coffins on the hill. Maybe someone who knew what had happened made each victim a secret, hand-sized funeral, since the real world had given them none.

It's a haunting thought, and the counting really does line up. But even this favourite theory has never been proved. There's no letter, no diary, no witness. It's the best guess, not a fact.

So which is it? Curses, drowned sailors, or secret funerals for murdered strangers? A detective who's honest has to shrug and say, we don't know. And weirdly, that's the best part. Nearly two hundred years of clever people have studied these little boxes, and the mystery has beaten every one of them. Some puzzles just stay open, and this is one of the very best.

The Ones That Survived

Here's something amazing to think about. When those boys found the seventeen coffins in 1836, all seventeen were there, lined up in the cave. But today, only eight are left in the whole world. So what happened to the other nine? The answer is a little bit funny and a little bit sad: boys happened.

The story goes that the lads who found them didn't understand they'd stumbled on a great mystery. To them it was just a pile of odd little boxes, so, being boys, they reportedly started chucking them at each other. Some got smashed, some got lost in the grass, and the survivors were knocked about. That's why several of the ones you can see today look battered, with their clothes torn or missing. Imagine if they'd known that grown-up scientists would still be puzzling over these things nearly two hundred years later. They might have been a bit more careful.

The eight that made it had quite a journey. They passed from person to person, were shown off as a curiosity, and at one point were even sold at an auction. Finally, in the year nineteen hundred and one, a woman named Christina Couper gave her eight little coffins to the National Museum of Scotland, and that's where they've stayed ever since. If the weather turns grey and drizzly today, that museum is the perfect place to go, it's warm, it's dry, and best of all it's free.

When you stand in front of that glass case, remember this. Scientists have done everything they can think of to these coffins. They've measured them, studied the wood, examined the tool marks, even looked at them with special machines to peek inside without opening them. And after all of that, all their cleverness and technology, they still cannot tell you who made them or why. The little coffins have kept their secret through everything.

Almost two hundred years. That's how long this puzzle has held out. People who lived and grew old and died never found out the answer, and passed the mystery on to the next lot, who passed it to us, who'll pass it to you.

So here's my challenge as you look at those eight survivors. Picture the hand that carved them, the fingers that stitched those tiny clothes, the person who climbed this very hill with a bundle under their coat and hid their little cargo behind three slabs of slate. Who were they? What were they thinking? You get to wonder, just like everyone before you. And think on this too: if a whole cave full of coffins could stay hidden on a busy city hillside, waiting years to be found, then somewhere out there, other secrets must still be waiting. Maybe one of them is on this hill, right under your feet.